Study Guide

In the style of Edexcel and OCR

How far do you agree that the *main* cause of the Arab–Israeli wars of 1948–9, 1967 and 1973 was the Arab desire to destroy the state of Israel?

Exam tips

The cross-references are intended to take you straight to the material that will help you to answer the question.

In this essay you need to assess the importance of the Arab desire to destroy the state of Israel in relation to other factors before making a judgement about whether it was the main factor. It is probably best to analyse each war in turn, identifying the main factors leading to war and then pull together your overarching assessment.

The 1948–9 war (pages 20–9)
The invasion by Arab armies suggests that the desire to destroy the new state was the main cause but were there other factors, even if less important? You might consider:

- retaliation for the expulsion of Palestinian Arabs from lands allocated to Israel
- the evidence which suggests that Transjordan, with the strongest Arab military force, did not wish to destroy Israel.

The 1967 war (pages 45–50)
Israel actually launched the attack in June but was it acting defensively? You need to analyse:

- The policies and actions of the main players, i.e. Syria, Jordan and Egypt. Evidence suggests that Syria was more intent on destroying Israel than the other two states.
- The importance of the PLO and Arab support for their guerrilla raids on Israel.
- The role of the radio, press and popular opinion in the Arab countries.
- Might Israel have launched the war in order to deter the Arab states from supporting Fatah attacks inside Israel? Or, to teach Syria a lesson or to force the Arab states to acknowledge Israel's permanence?

Making firm conclusions may be difficult. You have to make the best judgements you can based on the evidence.

The 1973 war (pages 54–7)
You need to ask yourself:

- Did Syria and Egypt attack in order to destroy Israel?
- Or did they attack to regain lands they had lost in 1967?